

THE PLAYS OF SHAKESPEARE

It is uncertain when some plays were written. These are the broadly agreed dates of authorship:

HISTORIES

Henry VI, part 1 (c. 1589–92)
Henry VI, part 2 (c. 1589–92)
Henry VI, part 3 (c. 1589–92)
Richard III (1592)
Richard II (1595)
King John (1596)
Henry IV, part 1 (1597)
Henry IV, part 2 (1598)
Henry V (1599)
Henry VIII (1613)

TRAGEDIES

Titus Andronicus (1592–93)
Romeo and Juliet (1595)
Julius Caesar (1599)
Hamlet (1601)
Troilus and Cressida (1602)
Othello (1604)
King Lear (1605)
Macbeth (1605)
Antony and Cleopatra (1606)
Timon of Athens (1606)
Coriolanus (1608)

COMEDIES

The Comedy of Errors (1590)
The Taming of the Shrew (1591)
Love's Labour's Lost (1593)
Two Gentlemen of Verona (1593)



The opening scene of *The Tempest* is a mighty shipwreck caused by Prospero the sorcerer.

A Midsummer Night's Dream (1594)
The Merchant of Venice (1596)
The Merry Wives of Windsor (1597)
As You Like It (1599)
Much Ado About Nothing (1599)
Twelfth Night (1600)

All's Well That Ends Well (1603)
Measure for Measure (1604)
Pericles Prince of Tyre (1607)
Cymbeline (1609)
A Winter's Tale (1610)
The Tempest (1611)

AMAZING FACTS

-  Shakespeare invented the word "assassination," among many others.
-  Shakespeare willed his fortune to his daughter, and only a bed to his wife.
-  *Cardenio*, a play thought to have been written by Shakespeare and performed during his lifetime, has been lost to history.
-  The Bard wrote an average of 1.5 plays per year from 1589 to 1613.



 The details of Shakespeare's life from 1579–1592 remain a mystery.

 There have been more than 500 film and TV adaptations of Shakespeare's dramas.

Hamlet film poster from 1948

QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

Q What is the mystery surrounding Shakespeare's sonnets?

A Shakespeare wrote 154 sonnets, some of which are addressed to an unidentified young nobleman and the remainder of which speak of a "dark lady". There are many theories surrounding not only the subjects of the Sonnets, but indeed whether Shakespeare was the author at all. When the Sonnets were published in 1609 they were addressed to "Mr. W. H.", which gave rise to the theory that the young man was Henry Wriothesley, Shakespeare's patron, whose initials, H. W. are W. H. in reverse.

Q How many works did Shakespeare author?

A As with all aspects of Shakespeare's life, the facts are not clear. The 36 plays published in the First Folio are mostly agreed upon. *Pericles* was published later, as was *Two Noble Kinsmen*, which Shakespeare is believed to have contributed to. Including the controversial lost *Cardenio*, this brings the potential total number of plays to 39. Shakespeare also wrote many poems, including 154 sonnets, *Venus and Adonis*, and *The Rape of Lucrece*.

Q What makes Shakespeare's use of language so unique and enduring?

A One of the factors may have been his huge vocabulary. His works contained some 30,000 words compared to just 3,000 used by the average adult today.



Henry Wriothesley, Earl of Southampton